



The Evolution of the Coupon

Forget the little old lady holding up the checkout lane, scrambling in the bottom of her purse for a stray coupon. Today, she is just as likely to be reaching for her cellphone for savings. Historically, for over one hundred years, the coupon was a piece of paper, but that has changed rapidly in recent years. The majority of the coupons I used in the 1980s had the statement “No Expiration Date” printed right on them. The earliest coupons certainly didn’t contain bar codes at the bottom for register scanners that hadn’t yet been invented. The GTIN-12 Universal Price Code that allowed cashiers to automatically scan coupons instead of manually entering them wasn’t introduced until 1974. In 2007, GS1 bar codes started appearing on the right, alongside the traditional code. A newer system of coding started replacing all the 12-digit UPCs at the beginning of 2010, offering more features for both stores and manufacturers to track and monitor sales and customize the coupon savings.